Jainism and Buddhism

Great thinkers like Buddha, Mahavira, Heraclitus, Zoroaster, Confucius and Lao Tse lived and preached their ideas in the 6th century BCE which enabled the rise of heterodox sects against the orthodox religion dominated by rites and rituals.

Causes for the rise of Jainism and Buddhism

- The primary cause of the religious factor- was the religious unrest in India in the 6th century BCE
- The complex rituals and sacrifices advocated in the Later vedic period were not acceptable to the common people
- The sacrificial ceremonies were also found to be too expensive
- The superstitious beliefs and mantras confused the people
- The teachings of Upanishads, an alternative to the system of sacrifices, were highly philosophical in nature therefore not easily understood by all

What was needed in the larger interests of the people?

- A simple, short and intelligible way to salvation for all people. Such religious teachings should also be in a language known to all
- This need was fulfilled by the teachings of Buddha and Mahavira

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Social and economic factors:

- The rigid caste system prevalent in India generated tensions in the society. Higher classes enjoyed certain privileges which were denied to the lower classes
- Also, the Kshatriyas had resented the domination of the priestly class
- Buddha and Mahavira belonged to Kshatriya origin
- The growth of trade led to the improvement in the economic conditions of the Vaisyas, the merchant class
- As a result, they wanted to enhance their social status but the orthodox varna system did not allow this. Therefore, they began to extend support to Buddhism and Jainism

Jainism

Life of Vardhamana Mahavira (539-467 BCE):

- Vardhamana Mahavira was the 24th tirthankara of the Jain tradition

- He was born at Kundagrama near Vaishali to Kshatriya parents Siddharta and Trisala
- He married Yasoda and gave birth to a daughter
- At the age of thirty years, he became an ascetic and wandered for twelve years
- In the 13th year of his presence, he attained the highest spiritual knowledge called Kevala Jnana. Thereafter, he was called Mahavira and Jina
- His followers were called Jains and the religion Jainism. He preached his doctrines for 30 years and died at the age of 72 at Pava near Rajgriha

Teachings of Mahavira:

The three principles of Jainism also known as Triratnas or three gems are:

- Right faith- belief in the teachings and wisdom of Mahavira
- Right knowledge- acceptance of the theory that there is no God and that the world has been existing without a creator and that all objects possess a soul
- Right conduct- observance of the 5 doctrines--
  - Not to injure life
  - Not to lie
  - Not to steal
  - Not to acquire property
  - Not to lead an immoral life

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Other teachings:

- Strictly follow the doctrine of ahimsa. It regarded that all objects, both animate and inanimate, have souls and possess life and feel pain when they are injured
- Mahavira rejected the authority of the Vedas and objected to the Vedic rituals. He advocated a very holy and ethical code of life
- Even the practice of agriculture was considered sinful as it causes injury to the earth, worms and animals
- To carry out the doctrine pf asceticism and renunciation to extreme lengths by the practice of starvation, nudity and other forms of self-torture

Spread of Jainism:

- Mahavira organized the Sangha to spread his teachings
- He admitted both men and women in the Sangha, and it spread rapidly and widely in Western India and Karnataka
- Rulers and dynasties who patronized Jainism- Chandragupta Maurya, Kharvela

of Kalinga and royal dynasties of south India such as the Ganges, the Kadambas, the Chalukyas and the Rashtrakutas

Division:

- By the end of the 4th century BCE, there was a serious famine in the Ganges valley. Many Jain monks led by Bhadrabagu and Chandragupta Maurya came to Shravanabelagola in Karnataka
- Those who stayed back in north India were led by a monk named Sthulababu who changed the code of conduct for the monks
- This led to the division of Jainism into two sects Svetambaras (whiteclad) by Sthulababu and Digambaras (skyclad or naked) by Bhadrababu

Jain councils

- First Jain council
  - Held at Pataliputra in 3rd century BCE and was presided by Sthulbhadra
- Second Jain council
  - Held at Vallabhi in 512 CE and was presided by Devardhi Kshmasramana
  - Final compilations of 12 Angas and 12 Upangas

Buddhism

Life of Gautama Buddha (567-487 BCE):

- Gautama or Siddharta, the founder of Buddhism, was born in 567 BCE in Lumbini Garden near Kapilavastu
- His father was Suddhodhana of the Sakya clan and mother Mayadevi
- As his mother died at childbirth, he was brought up by his aunt Parajapati Gautami
- At the age of sixteen he married Yashodhara and gave birth to a son, Rahula

What turned him into an ascetic?

- The sight of an old man, a diseased man, a corpse and an ascetic turned him away from worldly life
- He left home at the age of 29 in search of

Truth **Enlightenment:**

- Under a bodhi tree at Bodhgaya, he got enlightenment or nirvana, at the age of 35
- Since then he became known as the Buddha or the Enlightened One

First Sermon:

- He delivered his first sermon at Sarnath near Benares and for the next 45 years he led the life of a preacher
- He died at the age of 80 at

Kushinagar **Disciples:**

- Sariputta, Moggallanna, Ananda, Kassapa and Upali
- Kings like Prasenjit of Kosala and Bimbisara and Ajatasatru of Magadha accepted his doctrines and became his disciples
- He visited places like visited places like Benares, Rajgriha, Sravasti, Vaishali, Nalanda and

Pataligrama

Teachings of

Buddha

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Four noble truths:

- The world is full of suffering
- The cause of suffering is desire
- If desires are got rid off, suffering can be removed
- This can be done by following the Eightfold Path

Eightfold Path:

Right view

- Right resolve
- Right conduct
- Right mindfulness
- Right concentration
- Right effort

- Right livelihood
- Right speech

Other teachings:

- Buddha neither accepts god nor rejects the existence of god
- He laid great emphasis on the law of karma. He argued that the condition of man in this life depends upon his own deeds
- He taught that the soul does not exist. However, he emphasized ahimsa
- He did not make a direct attack on the caste system but he was against any social distinctions and threw open his order to all
- Therefore, Buddhism was a more social than religious revolution. It taught the code of practical ethics and laid down the principle of social equality

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